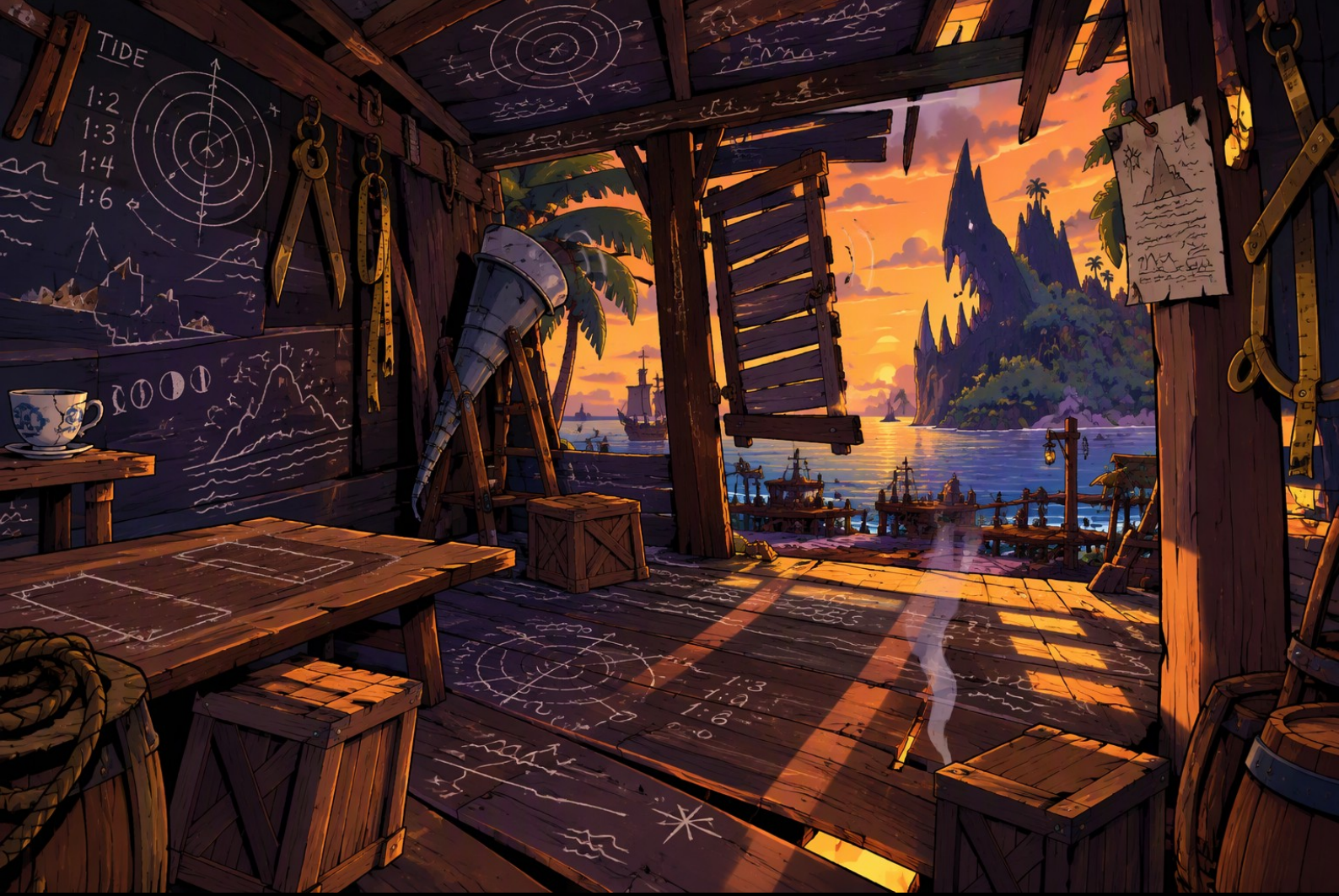
TAEKOMI
DUM... DUM...
DUM...
THE LOWEST BIDDERS

BONNNG...
Third time lucky.
Every seven years, the sea pulls back from Black Tooth Island.

Ting-TiNG!
Third tide, kid. Don't fall in.
Excuse me. Could you lower the bucket ... Please.
creeeak
♫
ting-TiNG!
You too.
tunk.
Nothing with history, nothing to say. Got it.
BANG BANG


TIDE
1:2
1:3
1:4
1:6
1:3
1:0
1:6

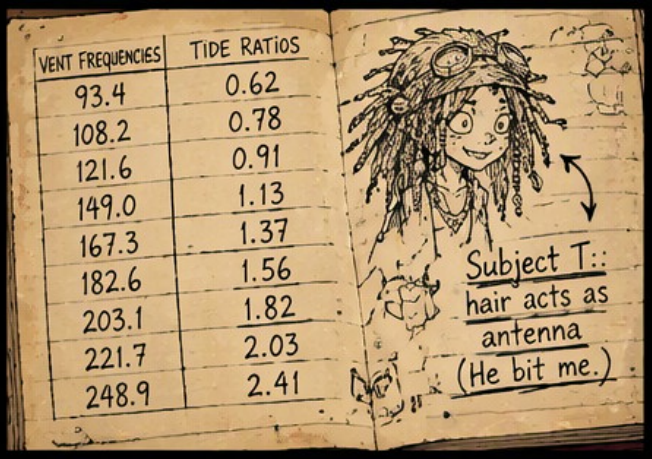
TIDE RATIO
Woody
It's Run night.
I wanted to...
BANG
BANG
VARIABLE (BLUE, LOUD)
?
"Gone to measure something bigger."
P.S. The floor is NOT a data point.
dum...
You hear that
ting.
dum...

TIDE RATIO
H/L = 1.37
VENT FREQ
÷ 93.4
÷ 108.2
÷ 121.6
÷ 149.0

I'll bring it back. Promise.

KLUNK

Woody + calipers = vent.
door (sulking)


VENT FREQUENCIES
TIDE RATIOS
93.4 0.62
108.2 0.78
121.6 0.91
149.0 1.13
167.3 1.37
182.6 1.56
203.1 1.82
221.7 2.03
248.9 2.41
Subject T:: hair acts as antenna (He bit me.)

tunk.

It's not a chord. It's a REPLY.
A reply to what?

DING...

Chores.
The Run's tonight!
Chores.
Hum to the rope. Not at it.
Sweep like the floor is sleeping.
Socks go where the draft breathes.
Auntie, why am I blue
Tuesday.

THE STRAND. DUSK.
The sea is gone a full mile, leaving the black obsidian sand, glistening flats and mirror pools.
THE DAMP DUKES DUKE
ALL HANDS ON DECK HANDS
...
BLINK
IT'S UPSIDE DOWN!
NO, NO— IT'S THE REAL ONE!
YOU'RE BOTH WRONG!
COCOA! HOT COCOA! TWO CASKS! GET IT WHILE IT'S HOT!
HOT COCOA 2 CASKS
Okay. Okay okay okay. Be cool. Be COOL.
PAST WINNERS
CREWS TO THE TABLE! TOKENS, ALE, GRIEVANCES. IN THAT ORDER! PUSHING IS FOR AFTER THE BELL!
BOP!

Crew of four, a flag, a name and a token. Seventeen and under. Over that, you watch.
I have a crew!
...Forming.
ting-a-ling
Is your hair ringing?
It's... decorative.
Run-night baby, right I heard about you. Were you born blue, or is that paint?
Depends who's asking.
Hot cocoa! Best in the islands!
COCOA 2 COINS
Bell's soon. Be here with four, a flag and a name, or don't be here.
SLAM
Y-Yes, ma'am!
Grumble grumble grumble grumble
Whoa—!

tunk.
Greetings, honored salvager. I am the dread—
Hey. Nice goggles. Mine are... also goggles.
The name's... the name's...
tunk..
Coil yourself. Neatly. Please.
HI.
bwoop- bwoop- bwoooon...
Strap's loose, goggles.
Nice bow, kid.

REGISTRATION

Lift that skiff and it's yours! Cake!

It's cake.
Sunny. Decorum.

Seventeen. My last tide. It will be done properly.

A crew of one and a laundry line. How rustic.
I'm... recruiting!

Sir Reginald, note it: embarrassing.

It's MY turn to plant it!

THE REGISTRATION QUEUE, BLACK OBSIDIAN BEACH, DUSK.
Bexley Brabazon-Quick, Chief Negotiator! You have a fourth and lack three. I have three and lack a fourth. That, my friends, is a merger!
SAMPLE
SAMPLE
Is that the vent man's ledger? Frequencies Tide ratios May I—
Hands OFF!
...
SAMPLE SHIFT
Sign here. Everything's pre-initialed.
Done!
Look at that crew...
...what are they even?
Deal!

BLACK TOOTH ISLAND. THE LAVA BUBBLE. OUR SECRET HIDEOUT.
Tea always fixes a lot of things.
DBSSSS...
Prime real estate. Rent is negotiable. For a small fee.
Forty-one sketches. Same subject. Goggles prominent.
That's REFERENCE MATERIAL!
BWOOP- BWOOP- BWOOOM~
Your goggles are a one-to-one replica of hers.
They're AMBER!
Tea for everyone.
"Anomaly 14-B. Jingles. Evades calipers. Will not be measured. Seems fond of the blue child. DO NOT CATCH."
Probably a vent whistle.
ting
SOME SECRETS ARE WORTH KEEPING.

The Brabazon-Quick Syndicate!
THE DREADFUL--
Lunch.
Name. Now. Or you're not a crew.
We are, technically, the lowest bidders on everything.
Lowest Bidders! SOLD!
LOWEST BIDDERS! SOLD!
LOWEST BIDDERS! SOLD!
Pffft.
CLANG- CLANG- CLANG- CLANG- CLANG!
LOWEST BIDDERS! SOLD!

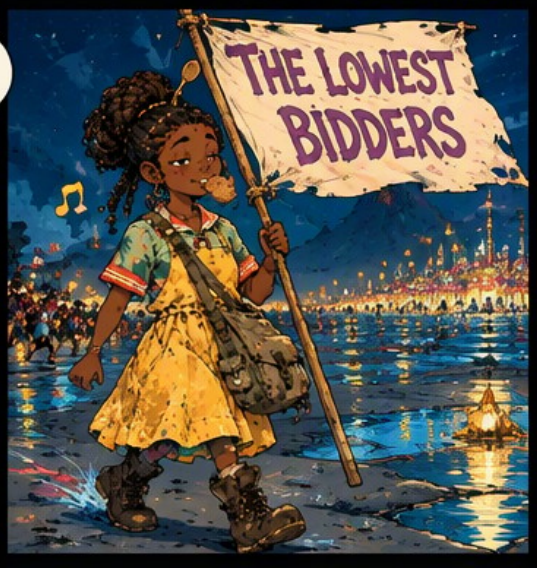
Three dares and one flag, mind the bell when it swings! Plant it first at the Mouth, but nobody goes IN!

SPLOOSH!

Faster! Flags are aerodynamic!

Pace yourselves! My ankles are non-refundable! Rental available, for a small fee!

Technically we're ninety-first.


THE LOWEST BIDDERS

WHEN THE BELL RINGS, WHATEVER'S UNSOLD BELONGS TO THE SEA.
WANTED: ANYTHING FROM THE ROOT. TOP COIN.
Genuine antique! Three hundred years old! The Admiral's own mast-rope!
CERTIFIED ANTIQUE
It still has the ropewalk's paper label.
Vintage label.
Excuse me... are you old?
tunk!
It's new.
Rope is rope. We need rope. I'm calling it provenance.
CLINK!
CERTIFIED ANTIQUE
Dumplings. Thanks!
Anything from down the Root, you bring to me. Top coin.
Nobody's been in the Root.
Exactly. Premium!

That's what it wants you to think.
The sea's a mile away.
That's what it wants you to think.
I can get you an introduction. Introductions are... available. For a small fee.
I don't know who you mean!
You know she's... okay, never mind.
Straight on, past the big shell.
Left, past the big shell. Definitely left.

bwoop-bwoop-bwoooon~
oooOoo~
Stock moves around here.
BEHOLD! Lanterns of the Market... BLAZE DRAMATICALLY!
~toastfn~
Toast.
Don't. Say. Anything.
Your Thursday low was four minutes early, technically.
...Five. Round down.
Bell's at midnight, goggles. After that, the sea keeps what's left.

Tide Hoard maps! Hand-drawn! X marks the spot!
TIDE HOARD MAPS
Real Maps! Real Treasure! (Probably!)
Every X is on this stall.
Or! The genuine article. Cursed to be perfectly correct.
YOU ARE HERE
Scratch.
Psst. Three dares. A bridge, a gate, and a stair that yawns.
Five coppers.
Tch. Fine.
Same tip. Three dares. A bridge, a gate, and a stair that yawns.
Five coppers.
She's selling HIM the same tip!
Last coin wins, blue.

In the name of the Admiralty, I claim this seabed, the mud and all fish thereon!
Not the mud ON my boots. These are not Admiralty property. Yet.
Cadet Brass, that's not how it's done. A senior cadet must plant it.
THUNK
YANK
That's the fourth time, sir.
Then we'll do a fifth, properly!
Sir. There's someone up that mast.
Not now, Cadet, I'm leading.
Navy. Be cool. Be COOL.

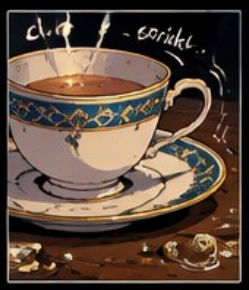
TURN BACK
GO THIS WAY
NO WAY
13
7
24
3
16
8
21
5
12
29
4
17
11
18
26
26
9

1. Do not look down.
2. I am looking down.

Eleven feet two inches. Dolly's personal record is... nine.
We could buy a plank. I'd need a plank dealer.
Please. He can't jump it. Please... help.
tunk
ting-TING!
snap!
I HAVE A LEDGER!
plink
I TOLD you it was antique.
It has a ropewalk label.

Rule one of a proper campaign: tea.
Rule two: cake.

The Run's course ends at the Mouth. My grandmother's chart does not.



Did we win the bridge?

We crossed the bridge.

Same thing.

- 3£
- 5£
- 2£
- 8£
- 1£
- 4£

What is that?
Laundry.

Appraised: Rubbish.
TOLL · TRADES · TALKS · ETC.
Leave this to the Chief Negotiator.
CRACK CRACK
CHARM OF MILD LUCK
BONK!
NOT REAL
DEED to the MOON
BONK!
NOT REAL
INTRODUCTION to a very IMPPORT.I.KT PERSON
BONK!
NOT REAL
BONK!
NOT REAL
BONK!
ALMOST
Excuse me.... could we go through Please'
NO ASKING. PAYING.
Fine! Everyone pays at once!
THE TALKER PAYS.

There is no Brabazon-Quick Syndicate.
It's just me. I talk fast so nobody notices there's nobody.

Six beads left... a gap where one fell away.
The plain, older bead remains.

DING

REAL.

CREAK

REAL.

ting

Don't. Anyone. Say. Anything.

Dolly was here (carrying snacks)
You told us two different ways at the Market!
That was directions. This is wisdom.
Never go up while it's shutting.
We agree.
That has never happened.
Open four seconds, shut seven, technically!
Do NOT ask the sleeping thing questions!
Dolly, what do you want out of tonight?
Evasive.
Dumplings.
HHHHAAAAAAAH...
Dolly was here (carrying snacks)

?!
hehehe-
hrrmmm...
HRRRMMMM!
SHLOOORP!
tikatikatika!
Go!
I'll hold it!
CREAAAK...
Not without
you!
I always
hold the door.
I always pack
the lunches.
Everyone goes
and I stay.
I'm tired
of staying.
I want to
GO!
Please.
She wants to go.
Hold it for her.
TAEKOMI!
ting-
TING!

ting-TING!
KRRRNNNCH!!
ting-TING!
I'M GOING!
plink
pink
plink

BONNNG... BONNNG.
tink... tink...
HOT COCOA 2¢
Margin says: "Mouth. No lock found. Door doesn't like me."
Flag in the socket. Door stays shut. Grown-ups go home.
Wait. Are you two related?
No.
No.
Door doesn't like anybody.
BONNNG... BONNNG.
tink... tink...

Go go GO!
THE LOWEST BIDDERS
SNIK!
43...
42...
KRRRK!
...Pole's shorter.
LIFT!
By right of the Run!
thunk
tink-a-link-a-LINK!
It's MY turn to plant!

BEHOLD! Rise, flag of the Lowest Bidders! Rise DRAMATICALLY!
bwoop-bwoop-bwoooon
Don't!
PFFT...
...Technically, that's a blanket.
HA-HA-HA-HA-HA!
It was a performance piece! Very avant-garde! Tickets are... available! For a small fee!

Stop asking like you're being watched.
ting-TING!
CREEEAAK...
Um. Hi. I don't really know what I'm doing. Can I come in?
Is he talking to the door?
Nothing to see. I'm looking at the moon.

FWOP!
Nobody's been down here. Imagine the *resale*.
It's warm.
It's... *breathing*.
hhhoooo...
hhhaaaa...
plip...
plip...
plip...

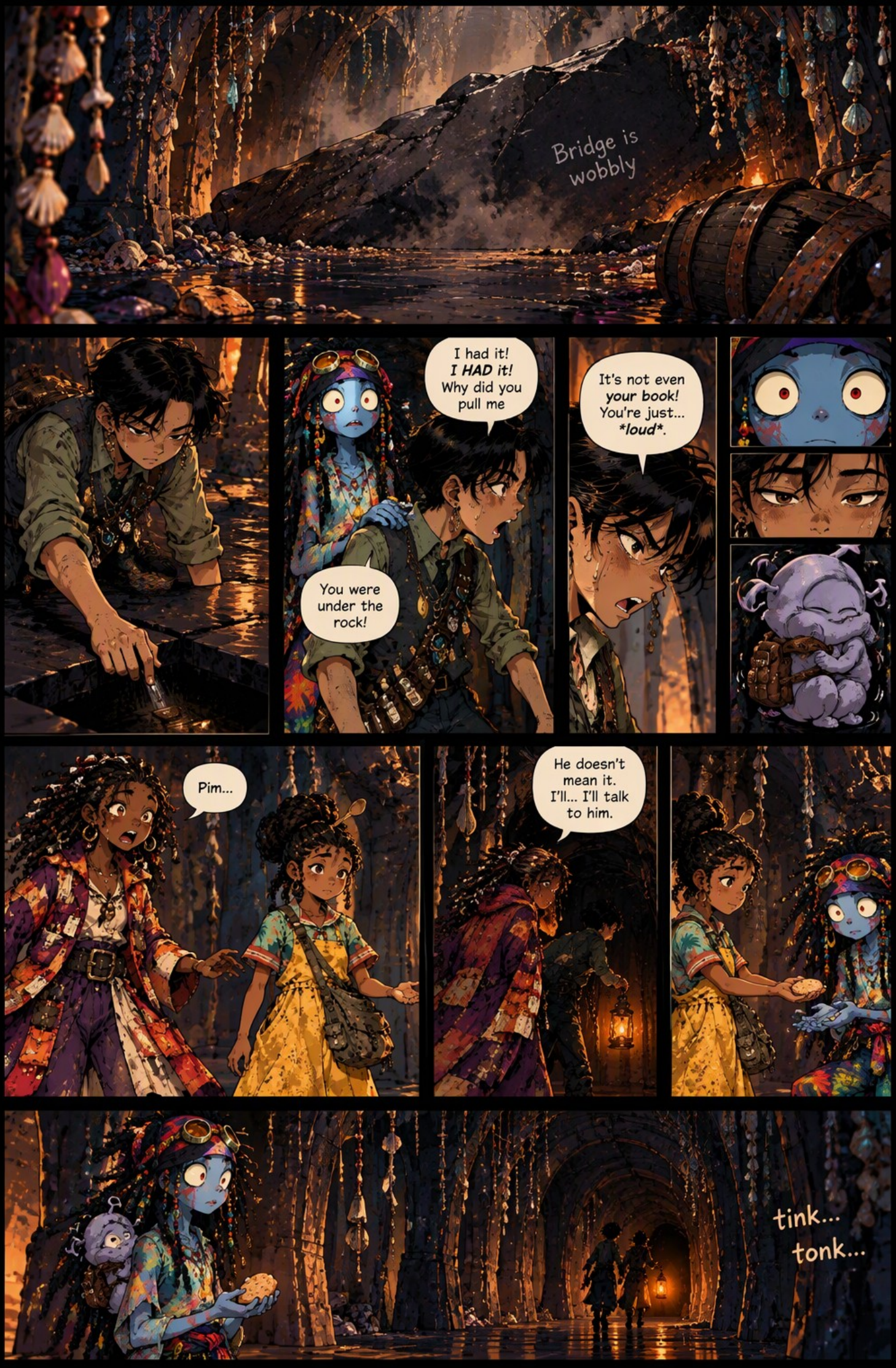
Margin says: "Anomaly 14-B. Jingles. Evades calipers. Fond of the blue child. DO NOT CATCH."
14-B again. Follows warm drafts downward. Homesick Do not anthropomorphize. Am anthropomorphizing.
"14-B again. Follows warm drafts downward. Homesick Do not anthropomorphize. Am anthropomorphizing."
Taekomi... I don't think Jangle is from you. I think it's from—
SPLOOSH!
WHEEEEE—FWUMP!
I'd like to file a complaint about the staircace.

tinkle-tink-a-tonk... ♫
♪ tinkle-tink-a-tonk... ♫
Don't touch anything. Not one chime. I mean it. ...Don't.
Eleven thousand... four hundred and... four.
Jangle ...Hey.
Don't touch anything. Not one chime. I mean it. ...Don't.

Left at the glowing shell, mind the second step, extra for the view.
KRRNNK!
Door was stuck. I fixed it.
You paid FIZZ?!
Refund. Minus handling. Last coin wins, blue. Nothing personal.
Forgive the intrusion. I believe the Run was only ever a doorway.
That's actually good business. I'm furious.
Bye beyond rentals~

tink-a-tonk...
tonk...
KLANG-tink...
TONK!
The warm wind stutters and sags.
STOP! Don't pull those!
That's THEFT!
...How much per chime?
Hush. Put them back.
...
No.
KRRRRRRK!
Is the floor supposed to do that?

Please, hold it. I mean it.
ting-TING!
hhhnnnnnng!
Go go go!
RUN!
tick


Bridge is wobbly
I had it! I HAD it! Why did you pull me
You were under the rock!
It's not even your book! You're just... *loud*.
Pim...
He doesn't mean it. I'll... I'll talk to him.
tink... tonk...

DEEP INSIDE THE ISLAND.
MORNINGS. A TINY HUT AT THE SETTLEMENT'S EDGE.
Hum to the rope. Not at it.
Sweep like the floor is sleeping.
These are chores!
Yes.
...They were never chores.
mmmm...
CREEEAK...

BONNNG...
BONNNG...
BONNNG...
...ssssshhhh...
...returning water....
!
Don't look at me. I didn't do this.
Fizz You sold—
Selling a route is business. Dropping a kid down a crack is not on the invoice.
Keep it. Refund is final.
Say one word about this to anyone and I'll deny it in three languages.
Your tidy one is sulking behind a rock. The curly one is giving him a talk. The spoon one's already coming.
Tide's turning, blue. You've got until the sea shakes hands with the Root.
ding
...time

He had your collar. Not the book. Your callar.
I think I've been asking the wrong way round.
The numbers stop here.
Wrong way round... what's that?
I don't know. It's not in the book.
Then we go ask.
Motion to go down, seconded by me, passed by me.
DUM...

DUM...

Okay.
I've got
nothing.

Technically...
it's a drum.
...Eleven seconds
a beat.

By right of the Run, and with every courtesy due, I ask this chamber to acknowledge me.
May this ancient chamber, seat of memory and of the deep, receive my humble petition and bear witness to---
HELLOOOO!
...
CRAAACK!
price.
dum... du-dum... dum...
Hush, put it BACK!
He's stealing the---

dum-DUM...
du...

Please! They're slipping!
THE LOWEST BIDDERS

ting-TING!
THE LOWEST BIDDERS

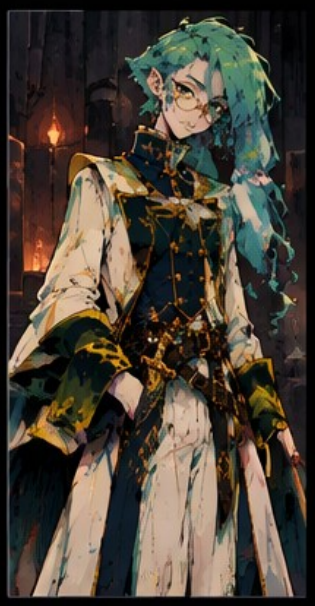
PULL!

plink

Why would you...
You were slipping!

Okay, new plan. Taekomi, you do the thing with the—

Let him.



Hi. I'm Taekomi. Are you okay?

dum...

DUM-DUM-DUM
mm-hm-hmmm~
DUM-DUM-DUM

THE HEART OF BLACK TOOTH ISLAND.
THE BLACK POOL LIES CALM AND GLASSY, ITS RIPPLES SETTLING INTO SLOW RINGS, AND EMBER LIGHT GLOWS WARM THROUGH GENTLE MIST OVER A FLOOR OF SHELLS AND OBSIDIAN.
ting-TiNG!
...nnng.
Bye, roommate.
bwoop- bwoop- bwoooon.

CLINK
CLINK
THE POOL BULGES —
— AND EVERY BASALT COLUMN RINGS AT ONCE!
WHEEEEE!
Technically this is NOT— AAAHH!
I'm selling tickets to this! AFTER! For a small fee!
...Splendid.
THOUSANDS OF SHELLS, BONES AND GLASS CHIMES — NOW IN PERFECT TUNE.
Ting
Ting
Ting...
OUT OF THE CRATER-LIKE BLOWHOLE, RINGED WITH POLISHED OBSIDIAN, INTO THE PALE BLUE PRE-DAWN SKY...
...THE RETURNING TIDE FOAMS ACROSS THE STRAND AND TINY STRANDED BOATS LIFT AND BOB.
WHOOOOSH!
DUM-DUM-DUM!

I'm drenched, I'm broke and I've never been happier.
...I'm also my own accountant, so that's fine.
Cake's fine!
SPLAT!
BONK!
Hello. I'm... only me, today. Is that all right.
dum...
The Barnacles hold the flag. I shall say so to the Marshal. And I shall ask her to hang four more plaques beneath it.
You're not going to gloat?
I planted a flag. You asked a question. Sir Reginald, note the difference.
67...

THE EPILOGUE
SOMEWHERE ON THE BLACK BEACH. SUNRISE.
♪ There was a crew that went down, seven souls and a codfish crowm... ♪
In the name of the Admiralty, I claim... the sea.
Sir, that is not how it works.
First one in the history of this wall. Don't make me regret it.
WENT DOWN
Born blue, or paint? Last time I asked, you said "depends".
Tuesday.
Written.
Looks better on him. Don't tell him.
Footnote: eleven.
Nice ask, Teekomi.
How do you know my—
Small island.
...Be cool.
That's the kind that lasts.

Every seven years, the sea comes back. And every seven years, somebody answers.
P.S. The floor said hi.
ting.
~toast~
...Hi.
bang...